# Dr. Seuss' The Lorax - Screenplay

## By Paul Cinco and Ken Daurio

(based on the book by Dr. Seuss, aka Theodore Geisel)

**LORAX: (Pg 2)** *(clears his throat and reads from a card)* I am the Lorax. I speak for the trees. Regarding the story that you're about to see: it actually happened, just take it from me. We open in Thneedville, a city they say that was plastic and fake, and they liked it that way! A town without nature, not one living tree.

## INTRODUCTION

*In 1971, one year after the US Environmental Protection Agency was established, Theodore Geisel, aka Dr. Seuss published The Lorax as a cautionary fable. In 2012 that fable was re-imagined for film, reaching a new generation of children with a very dire message. Now it is 2025, and it seems our leaders have forgotten the message yet again. This year, the Trump administration has moved to rescind longstanding forest protections, opening nearly 59 million acres of national forest to logging.[1] And his executive orders have reduced environmental oversight and relaxed endangered-species safeguards.[2] Today with this performance, I speak for our trees, our environment and our planet.*

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*Busy activity in Thneedville as its citizens start the day.*

**MAN: (Pg 2)** *(using a bike pump to inflate plastic trees/bushes)* FLOOSH! FLOOSH! POP! FLOOSH! FLOOSH! POP!

**WESLEY: (Pg 4)** *(swimming, he climbs out and dries off)* I went swimming and now I glow!

**DELIVERY MAN: (Pg 3-4)** *(carrying a large air tank on his shoulder)* In Theedville the air's not so clean. *(knocks on door)* O'Hare Air!

**WOMAN:** *(opens the door; she looks like she's smelled something rancid)* So we buy it fresh! *(puts on oxygen mask attached to the air tank and takes a whiff)* Aaaaaah!

**DELIVERY MAN:** We don't want to know where the smog and trash and chemicals go!

**SUNBATHER: (Pg 5-6)** We thank the Lord for all we've got--including this new parking lot!

**SUNBATHER 2:** Parking lot! Parking lot!

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**WOMAN:** *(excited as if she's seen a celebrity)* It's him! *(squeals)* It's Aloysius O'Hare, the man who found a way to sell air *(takes another hit from her oxygen mask)* and became a zillionaire! *(O'Hare waves to crowd from a massive TV screen; think Times Square)*

**TOGETHER:** Hip-hip-hooray! Hip-hip-hooray!

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**TED:** **(Pg 7-9)** *(rings the doorbell of his neighbor, Audrey's house – multiple times. While he waits for her to answer, sprays breath freshener into his mouth, and tries to tame his unruly hair)*

**AUDREY:** *(opens the door)* Oh, hi, Ted. Did your ball land in my backyard again?

**TED:** *(playing it cool)* Oh, hey, Audrey. Hi. No. Model airplane this time.

**AUDREY:** Hey, do you want to see something cool? Come on. *(leads him to look at a massive mural she is painting of a valley filled with Truffula trees)*

**TED:** *(staring up in awe)* Whoa! Did you... Did you paint this? This is amazing! What are those? *(pointing to the trees)*

**AUDREY:** *(smiling)* Those are trees. Real ones. They used to grow all around here. People said the touch of their tufts was softer than anything, even silk. And they smelled like butterfly milk! *(beat)* What I want more than anything is to see a real living tree!

**TED:** So if... I'm just thinking out loud here. If a guy somehow got you one...

**AUDREY:** I'd probably marry him on the spot! *(Ted smiles to the audience – he has a plan)*

***** **Ted's House** *****

**TED:** **(Pg 10-13)** So, Mom, do you happen to know if there's any place where I could get a real tree? -- one that grows out of the ground or whatever.

**MOM:** We already have a tree. It's the latest model. (makes a face) You would rather have some dirty, messy lump of wood that just sticks out of the ground? I don't even know what it does. *(proudly as she turns the lights on a fake tree in their yard)* We've got the Oak-amatic. *(commercial-style)* The only tree with its own remote! *(clicking the remote)* Summer . . . Winter . . . and DISCO!! *(sings and dances to *"The Hustle")* Doot doot doot doo-doot doo-doot doot doot!

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**TED:** *(mortified)* Mom! Stop!!! *(mom clicks the remote and stops, disappointed)* Let's just say I need a tree. Where would I go?

**GRAN:** You need to find the Once-ler. [He] is the man who knows what happened to the trees. People used to say if you brought him 15 cents, a nail and the shell of a snail, he'd tell you everything . . .

****** O'Hare Air Offices *****

**MARKETING GUY 1:** **(Pg 14-16)** Mr. O'Hare, we've got something that is going to take O'Hare Air to the next level.

**MARKETING GUY 2:** I know what you're thinking. 1) I've gotten rich selling people air that's fresher than the stinky stuff outside. 2) How could I possibly make even more money? *(laughs)* We can tell you, sir!

**MARKETING GUY 1:** *(holding up a plastic bottle)* O'Hare Purified Air! *(both open bottles and blow air into their mouths)* Oh, yeah!

**MARKETING GUY 2:** Oh, yeah! Freshness to go!

**TOGETHER:** *(taps bottles together, then as if in a commercial)* Please breathe responsibly.

**O'HARE:** *(beat)* You gotta be kidding me! You really think people are stupid enough to buy this?!

**MARKETING GUY 1:** Our research shows if you put something in a plastic bottle, people will buy it. And when we build a new factory to make plastic bottles, the air quality's going to get worse.

**MARKETING GUY 2:** Which will make people want our air even more and drive sales through the roof!

****** The home of the Once-ler*****

**(Pg 18-24)** Ominous sound effects. The wind whistles. Someone is watching him from inside through a boarded up window.

**TED:** *(getting more nervous with each step, arrives at the door, takes a deep breath and moves his shaking finger toward the doorbell)*

**ONCE-LER:** *(throwing open a window)* Who are you?!! And what are you doing here?!

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**TED:** *(startled)* Aaaaahhhhhh! I'm Ted. I'm Ted! *(out of breath)* Oh, can't breathe. Are you – are you . . .the Once-ler? Oh, man.

**ONCE-LER:** No one is supposed to come here! Leave me alone!

**TED:** *(regaining some composure, he holds out his hands full of change, a nail and a snail)* Listen, people say that if someone brings you this stuff, you'll tell them about trees. Real ones that grow out of the ground!

**ONCE-LER:** *(long beat)* Sorry, it's just . . . well, I didn't think anyone still cared about trees.

**TED:** Well, that's me. The guy who still cares. I'm here.

**ONCE-LER:** Do you want to know about trees? Why they're all gone? It's because of me. And my invention, the **Thneed. *(holds up a Thneed)* It all started a long time ago . . .

*****flashback story*****

**YOUNG ONCE-LER:** Well, here I go, Mom. Off to change the world with my Thneed!

**ONCE-LER:** So there I was, searching the globe, obsessed with finding the perfect material.

**YOUNG ONCE-LER:** *(singing)* Na na nana na na, Oh bop-bah-da-da-do-do-do, Thneed – Thneed – Thneed, La-la-la-la-la . . .

**ONCE-LER:** One day I found paradise.

**YOUNG ONCE-LER:** Whoa! *(looks around in awe)* This is the most beautiful place I have ever seen. This is the place! These Truffula Trees are just what I need! *(puts on work gloves and grabs a large axe)* Gonna chop one down and make my Thneed! **(Pg 28)** About to change the world! *(the phrase is echoed multiple times by both actors as he begins chopping down the tree)*

**ONCE-LER:** Little did I know that by chopping down that tree I had summoned a mystical creature as old as time itself. The legendary – slightly annoying – guardian of the forest *(beat)* The Lorax!

**LORAX:** **(Pg 29-30)** *(appears in a hail of lightning and thunder in disbelief and anger)* What the – Who the – Oh! Hey! Did you chop down this tree? Leave! Take your axe and get out!

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**YOUNG ONCE-LER:** Who are you?

**LORAX:** I'm – I'm the Lorax! I speak for the trees. You didn't see me magically appear out of that stump? **(Pg 32)** *(to audience)* Behold the intruder and his violent ways! *(to Once-ler)* Shame on you!

**YOUNG ONCE-LER:** Listen to me, you furry meatloaf. I'm gonna chop down as many tress as I need. News flash, not going anywhere! *(sticks his tongue out and does raspberries)* **(Pg 53)** *(packing up for town the next day)* Oh, yeah. I got a little jingle, gonna sell some Thneeds! *(put one on his head, one around his shoulders, one on a pair of pants and swings the others around his head like a lasso) (now he's at a makeshift booth in the center of town, hawking his Thneeds)* **(Pg 52)** This will change the world as we know it! It's a swimsuit! Hup-hey-oh! It's a hat! **(Pg 53)** *(singing)* Everybody needs a Thneed; a fine thing that all people need. *(taking money and handing out product)*

**TEEN GIRL:** **(Pg 55)** Oh my gosh, I totally want one!

**BOY:** **(Pg 57)** It's a net for catching butterflies! *(demonstrates)*

**FAT GUY:** A thing you use for exercise! *(demonstrates)*

**TOGETHER:** *(chanting)* The Thneed is good! The Thneed is great!

**YOUNG ONCE-LER:** **(Pg 58)** *(on the phone)* Mom! I told you I was gonna be a success. We're gonna be rich! *(to audience)* **(Pg 74-75)** All the customers are buying! Who cares if a few trees are dying? **(Pg 77)** I intend to keep on turning Truffula trees into Thneeds! And nothing is going to stop me!

**ONCE-LER:** *(long beat . . . then sadly)* **(Pg 61)** It was all downhill from there . . .

*******End Once-Ler's Fashback******

**TED:** **(Pg 79)** So this is really all your fault. You destroyed everything!

**ONCE-LER:** Yes. And each day I've sat here regretting everything I've done. But now I'm thinking . . . *(he rummages around and tosses something to Ted)* The last Truffula Seed. *(beat)* You need to plant it, Ted.

******Flashback to town earlier that day******

**O'HARE:** **(Pg 39)** *(broadly)* Oh, Teddy. I hear you've become interested in trees.

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**TED:** *(nervously)* Where'd you hear that?

**O'HARE:** *(smiling)* There's not much that goes on in Thneedville that I don't know about. *(beat)* Here's the deal. I make a living selling fresh air to people. Trees, they make it for free. So, when I hear people talking about them, I consider it a threat to my business. *(growls)* Listen to me, boy. Don't go poking around in things you don't understand.

******End Ted's Flashback******

**TED:** **(Pg 79)** But nobody cares about trees anymore.

**TOGETHER as TOWNSPEOPLE:** **(Pg 6)** Parking lot! Parking lot!

**ONCE-LER:** **(Pg 79-80)** Then make them care. Plant the seed in the middle of town where everyone can see. Change the way things are.

**TED:** *(dials Audrey's number frantically)* **(Pg 86-87)** Audrey! [I have] the last Truffula seed. And you're going to help me plant it right in the middle of town. Where everyone can see it. Let's go!! *(he rushes off to the town center)* **(Pg 93)** Okay, we have to get this in the ground.

**AUDREY:** But where? There's no dirt anywhere! *(stomps on the pavement)*

**TOGETHER as TOWNSPEOPLE:** **(Pg 6)** Parking lot! Parking lot!

**WOMAN:** **(Pg 93-96)** What do you think you're doing, kid?

**TED:** Um . . . I'm looking for a place to plan a tree. A real one!

**WOMAN:** *(takes a whiff from her air tank)* Why would we need a tree?

**O'HARE:** *(enters)* Exactly! Folks, the last thing you want around here is trees. They're filthy, spewing that sticky, nasty sap all over the place. They bring poisonous ants and stinging bees. And . . . I just thought of, you know, they make leaves! I mean, you know that right?! And these leaves, they just fall. They just fall wherever they want.

**AUDREY:** *(loudly)* Oh, come on! We know why you're REALLY against trees! Because they produce fresh air!

**TED:** For free!

**O'HARE:** *(gasps)* I am wounded! You have lied!

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**AUDREY:** It is not a lie! It's called ***photosynthesis***!

**O'HARE:** She's making that up! That's a made up word, people! We don't need trees! *(points at Ted)* That boy has a seed! We need to stop him! Who's with me?

**DELIVERY MAN:** O'Hare's right! Seeds will ruin us all!

**WOMAN:** *(takes a whiff from her air tank)* Yeah! Grab him!

**TED:** **(Pg 97-99)** *(climbs to the top of a wall)* I am Tedd Wiggins. *(beat)* I speak for the trees. *(beat)* And the fact is things aren't perfect here in Thneedville and they're only going to get worse unless we do something about it. And we can start by planting this! *(holds up the seed)*

**MARIE:** *(undeniable cuteness)* My name's Marie, and I am three. I would really like to see a tree! I say let it grow!

**TOGETHER:** *(reacts to her cuteness)* Awwwwwww!

**DAN:** My name is Dan

**ROSE:** And my name's Rose

**TOGETHER:** Our son Wesley kind of glows. And that's not good, so we suppose we should let it grow!

**GRAN:** I'm Granny Norma, I'm old and I've got gray hair, but I remember when trees were everywhere. And no one had to pay for air. So I say let it grow!

**O'HARE:** My name's O'Hare, I'm one of you. The things you say just might be true. It could be time to start anew . . . . Naw! I say let it Die! *(chanting)* Let it die! Let it die!

**WOMAN:** **(Pg 101)** *(takes a whiff from her air tank)* It's time to banish all your greed!

**DELIVERY MAN:** Imagine Thneedville flowered and treed! Let it grow!

**TOGETHER:** *(Cheering) (long beat)*

**AUDREY:** *(utter seriousness)* Unless someone like you cares a whole awful lot . . .

**TED:** Nothing is going to get better.

**TOGETHER:** It's not!

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author:  Paul Cinco and Ken Dario***
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## AWARD HISTORY

***2024 National Qualifier***
***NIETOC***
***MN State Qualifier***

*Introduction – Data Sources*

[1] *https://www.reuters.com/legal/litigation/trump-administration-rescind-policy-protecting-undeveloped-forests-2025-06-23/*

[2] *https://www.nrdc.org/press-releases/executive-order-seeks-accelerate-widespread-logging-federal-forests?utm_source=chatgpt.com*

**The Hustle – music and dance moves can be found here https://www.youtube.com/shorts/Gp5c1j_L5VY*

***A Thneed is a fictional, versatile knitted item that can be fashioned into various garments and items, including a shirt, hat, or even a carpet, but its production eventually leads to the destruction of the environment*



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